



## IRELAND

**Capital city:** Dublin**Area:** 27,135 sq miles  
(70,280 sq km)**Population:** 4,000,000**Official languages:** Irish,  
English**Major religions:**  
Christian 91%, other 9%**Government:** Multiparty  
democracy**Currency:** Euro**Adult literacy rate:** 99%**Life expectancy:** 77 years**People per doctor:** 500**Televisions:** 417 per 1,000  
people

## IRISH PUBS

Much social life in Ireland centers around the pub, or bar, where people meet to drink, chat, and exchange news. Stories from Irish history are told through songs, and bars are often alive with the sound of folk music. Irish stout – a strong, dark beer with a creamy, pale head – is the favorite drink. One of the largest breweries in Europe is found in Dublin, opened by the Guinness family 200 years ago.

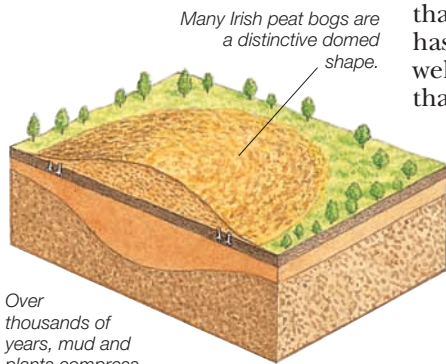
## IRELAND

THE GREEN PASTURES of Ireland are kept fertile by the country's mild, wet climate. Ireland was once ruled by Britain. In 1922, southern Ireland – which makes up about two-thirds of the island – became an independent nation, while Northern Ireland remained part of the United Kingdom. Natural resources are few and traditionally much of the population was employed in agriculture. However, a dramatic growth in tourism and light industry has radically altered people's lives and has turned Ireland into one of Europe's recent economic success stories.



## RACEHORSES

The lush pastures of Ireland provide excellent grazing land for racehorses. These fine Irish thoroughbreds are world famous and frequently win major international races. The animals, bred on stud farms, are valuable sources of income for the Irish economy. Buying and selling horses is also popular, and country horse fairs are a familiar sight.



Many Irish peat bogs are a distinctive domed shape.

Over thousands of years, mud and plants compress to form peat.

## PEAT

Ireland has few natural resources, such as coal or oil, that produce energy. What it does have are huge peat bogs. Peat consists of dead, rotted plants that have been compressed and can be burned as fuel. Some villages have their own peat supplies, and there are also vast government-owned areas that are dug out by mechanical cutters. These provide fuel for large power plants that generate electricity.



## RELIGIOUS LIFE

The Irish are a devout people and the Catholic Church plays an important role in daily life. Religious processions are held regularly, and shrines, many dedicated to the Virgin Mary (Jesus's mother), are dotted around the country. In addition to running schools and hospitals, the Church has an influence on the social life of the country and opposes abortion and birth control. Divorce was illegal in Ireland until 1995.



Bustling O'Connell Street is Dublin's major roadway.

## DUBLIN

The capital of Ireland, Dublin, is steeped in the country's history. This compact city was the focus for the revolt against British rule and it was here, in 1922, that the Irish state was born. In recent years, Dublin has attracted manufacturing and service industries, as well as many people from other parts of the country that have come here in search of work.

Peat is still gathered by hand in many parts of Ireland.



The peat is cut out in blocks and then stacked and left to dry.

## Find out more

BEER BREWING: 117

COAL AND OIL: 96, 152, 162

NORTHERN IRELAND: 89

RELIGIONS: 274–275